Poetry of Bonnie Parker

By Bonnie Parker (ed Alexander Baron)

INTRODUCTION

To many ordinary citizens during the Great Depression, bank robbers were seen as victims of injustice driven to commit crimes -- folk heroes wreaking vengeance on a callous economic system. The notoriety of Bonnie and Clyde was bolstered by wild shootouts with police, spectacular car chases, and the romance of two lovers outside the law. But the truth of the situation wasn't nearly so romantic. Both Bonnie and Clyde had spent time in prison before their famous shoot out and were small time gangsters. During Bonnie's first prison stint, she penned the poem The Story of Suicide Sal which shows her initial fascination with the gangster lifestyle at the young age of 21.

The Story of Suicide Sal

We each of us have a good "alibi"
For being down here in the "joint";
But few of them really are justified
If you get right down to the point.

You've heard of a woman's "glory"
Being spent on a "downright cur,"
Still you can't always judge the story
As true, being told by her.

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As long as I've stayed on this "island,"
And heard "confidence tales" from each "gal,"
Only one seemed interesting and truthful --
The story of "Suicide Sal."

Now "Sal" was a gal of rare beauty,
Though her features were coarse and tough;
She never once faltered from duty
To play on the "up and up."

"Sal" told me this tale on the evening
Before she was turned out "free,"
And I'll do my best to relate it
Just as she told it to me:

I was born on a ranch in Wyoming;
Not treated like Helen of Troy;
I was taught that "rods were rulers"
And "ranked" as a greasy cowboy."

Then I left my old home for the city
To play in its mad dizzy whirl,
Not knowing how little of pity
It holds for a country girl.

There I fell for "the line" of a "henchman,"
A "professional killer" from "Chi";
I couldn't help loving him madly;
For him even now I would die.

One year we were desperately happy;
Our "ill gotten gains" we spent free;
I was taught the ways of the "underworld";
Jack was just like a "god" to me.

I got on the "F.B.A." payroll
To get the "inside lay" of the "job";
The bank was "turning big money"!
It looked like a "cinch" for the "mob."

Eighty grand without even a "rumble" --
Jack was last with the "loot" in the door,
When the "teller" dead-aimed a revolver
From where they forced him to lie on the floor.

I knew I had only a moment --
He would surely get Jack as he ran;
So I "staged" a "big fade out" beside him
And knocked the forty-five out of his hand.

They "rapped me down big" at the station,
And informed me that I'd get the blame
For the "dramatic stunt" pulled on the "teller"
Looked to them too much like a "game."

The "police" called it a "frame-up,"
Said it was an "inside job,"
But I steadily denied any knowledge
Or dealings with "underworld mobs."

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The "gang" hired a couple of lawyers,
The best "fixers" in any man's town,
But it takes more than lawyers and money
When Uncle Sam starts "shaking you down."

I was charged as a "scion of gangland"
And tried for my wages of sin;
The "dirty dozen" found me guilty --
From five to fifty years in the pen.

I took the "rap" like good people,
And never one "squawk" did I make.
Jake "dropped himself" on the promise
That we make a "sensational break."

Well, to shorten a sad lengthy story,
Five years have gone over my head
Without even so much as a letter--
At first I thought he was dead.

But not long ago I discovered
From a gal in the joint named Lyle,
That Jack and his "moll" had "got over"
And were living in true "gangster style."

If he had returned to me sometime,
Though he hadn't a cent to give,
I'd forget all this hell that he's caused me,
And love him as long as I live.

But there's no chance of his ever coming,
For he and his moll have no fears
But that I will die in this prison,
Or "flatten" this fifty years.

Tomorrow I'll be on the "outside"
And I'll "drop myself" on it today;
I'll "bump 'em" if they give me the "hotsquat"
On this island out here in the bay...

The iron doors swung wide next morning
For a gruesome woman of waste,
Who at last had a chance to "fix it,"
Murder showed in her cynical face.

Not long ago I read in the paper
That a gal on the East Side got "hot,"
And when the smoke finally retreated
Two of gangdom were found "on the spot."

It related the colorful story
of a "jilted gangster gal."
Two days later, a "sub-gun" ended
The story of "Suicide Sal."

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TRANSITION

Bonnie and Clyde remained at large until a Texas posse ambushed them on May 23, 1934. Dying together in a proverbial hail of bullets—the Texas lawmen fired over 187 rounds into the couple—helped perpetuate the romance surrounding their short, desperate, and destructive lives.

But during their crime spree, Bonnie Parker sent poems and photographs to newspapers, heralding the Barrow Gang's exploits and defending her honor. Her poem The Story of Bonnie and Clyde (aka The Trail's End), depicts the pair as populist desperadoes, misunderstood and star-crossed lovers driven to a life of crime.

The Story of Bonnie and Clyde (aka The Trail's End)

You've read of the tale of Jesse James –
Of how he lived and died,
But if you're in need
Still of something to read,
Here's the story of Bonnie and Clyde.

No Bonnie and Clyde are the Barrow gang,
And I'm sure that you all will have read,
How they rob and they steal,
And the lowlife who squeal
Are found dead with a slug through the head.

There are lots of untruths to these write ups,
For they're neither as ruthless as that,
Though their nature is raw
And they hate all the law –
The stool pigeons, the spotters and rats.

People say they are cold-blooded killers,
Claiming they are both heartless and mean,
But I say this with pride,
That when first I met Clyde
He was honest and upright and clean.

But the law fooled around,
Kept on sending him down,
And kept locking him up in a cell,
Until he said to me:
"I will never be free,
So I'll meet a few of them in Hell."

The road they took was dimly lighted,
There were no highway signposts to guide,
But they made up their minds
If the roads were all blind
That they wouldn't give up till they died.

The road's growing dimmer and dimmer,
Until sometimes you hardly can see,
But it's fight man to man,
Get as far as you can,
For they know they can never be free.

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From heartbreak many people have suffered,
And from weariness many have died,
But take it in all,
People's troubles are small
Till they end up like Bonnie and Clyde.
If a lawman is shot down in Dallas,
And they haven't a clue or a guide,
If they can't find a fiend,
They just wipe their slate clean
And announce it was Bonnie and Clyde.

There are only two crimes in this country
They've not tried to pin on Barrow's mob,
It's said they had no hand
in the kidnap demand
Nor the Kansas City depot job.

A newspaperboy said to his buddy:
"I wish Bonnie and Clyde would get jumped,
In these awful hard times
We would make a few dimes
If a handful of cops would get bumped."

The police haven't go the report yet,
But I heard from Clyde only today,
He said: Don't start no fights,
Cos we ain't working nights,
We're joining up with the NRA.

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From Irving to West Dallas viaduct
Is what's known as the Great Divide,
Where the women are kin,
And the men are real men,
And they won't "stool" on Bonnie and Clyde.

If they tried to act like decent citizens
And rented a nice little flat,
About the third night
They'd receive an invite
From a sub-machine gun's rat-tat-tat.

They don't think they're too tough or desperate,
They realize the law always wins,
They've been shot at before,
But they neither ignore
That death must be the price of their sins.

Some day soon they will go down together,
And they'll bury the two side by side,
To few it'll be grief,
To the law a relief . . .
But it's death for Bonnie and Clyde.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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